

Phillip Pullman: "Dark Materials trilogy"

I need to say something about Pullman because there is good reason to believe that Rowlings had him in mind when writing "The Chamber of Secrets".

Pullman published his first part in 1995 a year or more ahead of the first Harry Potter book. Rowlings had met him at a conference in the 90's

The book was marketed to young adults tho he had no targeted group in mind when it published. It functions in part as a retelling and inversion of Jon Milton's epic fantasy "Paradise Lost". The series has attracted controversy for its criticism of religion.

The dominant religion resembles Christianity and in the later books in the series explicitly named. Adam and Eve are referenced in the text.

The Church is called the "Magisterium", the same name as the authority of the Catholic Church and exerts a strong control over society. However, the headquarters have moved from Rome to Geneva by his fictional Pope John Calvin.

There was not a creator in his story but rather matter became conscious of itself and developed "dust". Dust becomes conscious of itself and the Authority was the first figure that condensed from the dust. Others coming later at first believed he was the creator but some angels decided he wasn't and thus the fall came about and all else came from that.

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The figure of authority dies in the story showing he has a reality that is only symbolic. The last expression on his face is one of profound, exhausted relief.

These are based on the Gnostic myth. The idea that the world we live in, the physical universe, is actually a false thing, made by a false god, and the true God, our true home, is infinitely distant, far away from that.

This sense is what we find in popular culture (The X files, The Matrix).

Everything we see is the false creation of some wicked power that is trying to deceive us.

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Philip Pullman's opposition
to C.S. Lewis

Fantasy and Religion Bibliography 2026

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